

Training Academy: Curriculum and Badge Program

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Summary

The Training Academy turns the badge competency matrix into a training program. It onboards every new hire, trains current staff on the badges they are missing, and runs the committee that awards badges and recommends promotions. One manager owns it, preferably the new Senior Manager. A committee of 2–3 managers, L4 Principals, L3 Seniors and 2 rotating team leads runs it with the QA department.

What the Academy delivers:

- **Onboarding:** 2 weeks for new hires, in monthly cohorts of 4–6, so each hire is on track for L2 at 6 months.
- **Badge courses:** 9 courses, 5 core (C1–C5) and 4 advanced (A1–A4). Each one ends in supervised production and an assessment.
- **Cross-training:** everyone holds the 5 core badges by June 30, 2027.
- **Leadership track:** preparation for future team leads and managers.
- **Reporting:** a monthly team badge grid and Academy report to the leadership board.

Training happens mostly on live work. About 20% of each badge is classroom time and 80% is supervised production, checked by a badge-holder.

Governance: the Academy Committee

The Academy Committee owns training, badge awards and promotion recommendations. One manager chairs and owns it, and no member ever decides alone on their own team.

Seat	Who	Number	Term	Role on the committee
Chair (Academy owner)	A manager, preferably the Senior Manager	1	Standing	Owns the curriculum, calendar and training hours; confirms badge awards; chairs the promotion panel; reports monthly
Manager members	Team managers from different teams	2-3	12 months, staggered so one changes every 6 months	Calibrate placements and promotions; each sponsors 2-3 badge courses
L4 Principals	Holders of the advanced badges they teach	2	12 months	Lead trainers and assessors for advanced badges
L3 Seniors	Strong core-badge holders	2	6 months	Trainers and assessors for core badges; buddies for new hires
Team leads	Rotating through all team leads	2	1 quarter	Bring floor feedback; run supervised production in their teams; join coaching assessments
QA reviewer	The existing QA department	1	Standing	QA scores, rulings on critical errors, a seat on every Badge Panel

Team lead rotation: 2 team leads join each quarter, so 8 team leads serve each year and every team lead serves about once every 18 months. Bridge shift leads are included in the rotation but serve outside their bridge term.

What the committee owns:

- The curriculum, course materials and the yearly training calendar.

- New-hire onboarding and each hire's 6-month plan to L2.
- The pool of trainers and assessors, and their quarterly calibration.
- Badge awards, suspensions and reinstatements.
- Quarterly promotion decisions for L1 to L4, and shortlists for team lead and manager posts.
- The monthly team badge grid, and training priorities for teams with gaps.
- Placement appeals and badge appeals.

Decision rules:

- **Quorum:** the chair, 1 manager member, the QA reviewer and 2 other members.
- **Badges:** a Badge Panel scores each assessment: the QA reviewer plus 2 assessors from other teams. The chair confirms the award, and ClickUp routing switches on the same day.
- **Promotions (L1-L4):** the chair and 2 managers from outside the person's team confirm each case.
- **Team lead and manager posts:** the committee shortlists from internal applicants, and the director and assistant directors approve.
- **Conflicts of interest:** members step out of any decision on their own team or direct reports.
- **Appeals:** one per decision, heard within 10 business days by members who did not make the original decision.

Learning paths

A new hire reaches L2 in about 6 months by earning the 5 core badges in a set order. Advanced badges then lead to L3 and L4. The order follows each badge's prerequisites, so no one starts a course they can't finish.

Stage	Badges earned, in order	Typical time	Exit criteria
Onboarding	Orientation, systems, NSA basics; starts C1 and C4	Weeks 1-2	Passes the onboarding written and practical checks
L1 RCM Specialist I	C1 and C4 (months 1-2), C5 (month 3), C2 (months 4-5), C3 (month 6)	6 months	All 5 core badges; work units at 100% of target; QA at or above 95%

Stage	Badges earned, in order	Typical time	Exit criteria
L2 RCM Specialist II	2 advanced badges: A2 (needs C2 and C5), A3 (needs C1 and C3) or A1 (needs a coding certification)	At least 12 months	Net Recovery in the top 40% of the tier; QA at or above 97%
L3 Senior RCM Specialist	A third advanced badge, often A4 Payer Strategy (needs A2); Trainer certification	At least 18 months	Net Recovery in the top 20%; teaches at least one Academy module
L4 Principal	Leads a specialty group; Academy trainer and assessor	Ongoing	Keeps 3 or more advanced badges active

Leadership ladder: an L3 can apply for team lead after the Team Lead readiness course and a coaching assessment. A team lead with 12 months in the role, or an L4, can apply for manager after the Manager readiness course.

Current staff (January 2027): experienced staff skip the order. They fast-track the badges for work they already do, then cross-train only on the core badges they are missing (see Rollout).

New-hire onboarding

New hires start in monthly cohorts of 4–6, on the first Monday of the month. They spend 2 weeks in the Academy and then join a team for supervised work. Each hire gets an L3 buddy from the committee's trainer pool and a written 6-month plan to L2.

Day	Topic	Format	Check
1	Welcome; the ER out-of-network revenue cycle end to end; HIPAA, PHI and security rules; approved use of AI tools	Classroom	HIPAA quiz, 100% required
2	Systems: eCW, ClickUp (Today list, statuses, routing), patient hub, payer portals	Hands-on lab	Navigation task in each system

Day	Topic	Format	Check
3	No Surprises Act basics: emergency services, out of network, QPA, Open Negotiation, IDR timeline; NNSA and state-regulated plans	Classroom and scenarios	20-question quiz, 85% or higher
4	C1 module, part 1: claim lifecycle, mailing log, receipt confirmation, payer portals	Classroom; shadow a C1 holder	Logging exercise
5	C1 module, part 2: payer call script, reference numbers, next-action dates; week 1 review	Recorded call review; role-play	Mock call scored with the C1 checklist
6	C4 module, part 1: ERA and EOB reading, adjustment codes, exception queue	Classroom and lab	Read 10 EOBs
7	C4 module, part 2: manual posting, IDR award payments, refunds, batch balancing	Lab on training data	Balance a 15-item batch
8	Documentation: reading an ER chart, E/M levels (99281–99285) at a glance, the medical-necessity report and approved prompts	Classroom	Chart-reading exercise
9	Deadlines and quality: the deadline board, QA checklists, critical errors, escalation; the US desk ticket flow	Classroom; visit QA	Critical-error quiz
10	Final checks; meet the team; buddy assigned; supervised production plan agreed	Assessment and team handover	Written test (80% or higher) and practical task

After the 2 weeks:

- **Weeks 3–8:** supervised production for C1 and C4 in the team, with every case signed off by a badge-holder in ClickUp.
- **Day 30, 60 and 90:** check-ins with the buddy and team lead. Day 90 confirms that the L1 targets are met: work units at target and QA at or above 90%.
- **Months 3–6:** C5, C2 and C3 courses in the Academy calendar, then L2 review at the next quarterly promotion window.

A hire who fails a day-10 check repeats that module with the next cohort. Two failed checks lead to a review by the chair and the hiring manager.

Core badge curriculum

The 5 core badges take 46 classroom hours in total, plus supervised production on live work. Every course follows the same four steps: Academy module, supervised production, Badge Panel assessment, award. The case counts and pass marks below come from the badge competency matrix.

Badge	Prerequisite	Classroom	Supervised production	Assessment	QA to earn	Usual trainer
C1 Claim Follow-up	None	8 hours	40 claims, 5+ payers	Live check of 10 claims; 3 recorded calls	95%	L3 C1 holder
C2 Open Negotiation	C1	12 hours	30 notices, 10 negotiations	20-scenario test (90%); 1 notice; 1 role-play	98%	L4 with A2 or A4
C3 NNSA Appeal	C1	10 hours	25 appeals, 2+ types	2 appeals written from case files	95%	L3 C3 holder
C4 Payment Posting	None	8 hours	100 postings, incl. 20 manual and 10 IDR awards	30-item batch that balances exactly	99%	L3 C4 holder
C5 Medical-Necessity Report	None	8 hours	30 reports	5 charts, zero factual errors	97%	L3 or A1 holder

C1. Claim Follow-up and Receipt Confirmation

1. Claim lifecycle and the mailing log; confirming receipt within 21 days (2 hours).
2. Payer portals and claim status codes (2 hours).

3. The payer call script, reference numbers and review of recorded calls (2 hours).
4. ClickUp statuses, next-action dates and resubmission requests to Logistics (2 hours).

C2. Open Negotiation (OMB)

1. NSA eligibility: emergency service, out of network, plan type, date of initial payment or denial (3 hours).
2. The QPA and the Open Negotiation notice: claim items, proof of delivery, the 30-business-day window (3 hours).
3. The pricing guide, decision rights and counter-offers (3 hours).
4. Negotiation practice: role-plays on common payer positions (3 hours).

C3. NNSA Appeal

1. NNSA process maps and state-regulated plans (2 hours).
2. Code appeals and money appeals; each payer's appeal limits (2 hours).
3. The appeal letter library and citing the medical-necessity report (3 hours).
4. Non-NSA denials, the 12-month closing rule and the high-dollar final review (3 hours).

C4. Payment Posting and Reconciliation

1. ERA and EOB reading; adjustment codes (2 hours).
2. The ERA exception queue and manual posting (2 hours).
3. IDR award payments: matching to the determination within 2 business days; flagging awards unpaid after 30 days (2 hours).
4. Refund flags, claim closure and batch balancing (2 hours).

C5. Medical-Necessity Report and Documentation

1. Reading the ER chart: complaint, acuity, workup, treatment, disposition (2 hours).
2. The approved LLM tool, the current prompt version and PHI rules (2 hours).
3. Fact-checking every statement against the chart (2 hours).
4. Filing to the patient hub within 1 business day; the QA checklist (2 hours).

Course materials for each badge: a trainer guide, slides, a scenario bank, the QA checklist from the QA department, and a ClickUp supervised-production template. The chair approves every update to them.

Advanced badge curriculum

Advanced badges take 54 classroom hours across the four courses and carry stricter reviews, because errors here cost the most. Each team needs at least 2 holders of each badge, so the committee sets cohorts from the team badge grid, not from requests alone.

Badge	Prerequisite	Classroom	Supervised production	Assessment	QA to earn	Usual trainer
A1 Coding (Certified)	CPC, COC or CCS certification; C5	16 hours	200 charts: every one of the first 50 reviewed, then a 20% sample	Blind coding test of 50 charts	95%	L4 A1 holder, with QA
A2 IDR Packet and Offer Strategy	C2 and C5	16 hours	20 batched disputes, 160+ codes	Full packet and written offer rationale for one dispute	97%, plus 98% first-pass tickets	L4 A2 holder
A3 MVA and Adjuster Negotiation	C1 and C3	10 hours	15 settlements	Role-play with the assessor as adjuster; 3 closed files	95%	L4 A3 holder
A4 Payer Strategy	A2, and L2 or above	12 hours	Co-own one payer playbook with a Principal for 1 quarter	Present and defend the playbook to the panel	90% on the scorecard	L4 A4 holder

A1. Coding (Certified)

1. ER professional E/M leveling (99281–99285) and facility levels (4 hours).
2. Procedures, ICD-10 specificity and medical decision-making documentation (4 hours).
3. Modifiers, claim scrubbing, and HCFA and UB-04 preparation for Logistics (4 hours).
4. Current coding guideline updates and the latest audit findings from the coding quality owner (4 hours).

The company pays for the certification exam, renewals and CEUs. Uncertified coders get exam preparation support and a target exam date.

A2. IDR Packet and Offer Strategy

1. The IDR timeline and every Gateway action (2 hours).

2. Batching rules: same payer, same or similar service codes, within the allowed window (2 hours).
3. IDR entity selection and objections (2 hours).
4. Setting offers with the pricing guide and outcome data (3 hours).
5. Writing the packet: answering the QPA and the additional factors (acuity, complexity, good-faith negotiation) (4 hours).
6. US desk tickets, determinations logging and outcome review (3 hours).

If Model B goes ahead, add a 4-hour module on building bundles and the Bundle QA checklist.

A3. MVA and Adjuster Negotiation

1. Order of coverage: auto, PIP, MedPay, health and liability (3 hours).
2. Carrier filing limits, liens and attorney correspondence (3 hours).
3. Records release and valid authorization (1 hour).
4. Adjuster negotiation role-plays (3 hours).

A4. Payer Strategy

1. Reading outcome data: QPA patterns, settlements and IDR entity results by payer (3 hours).
2. Building a payer playbook: offer ranges, negotiation behavior, escalation contacts (3 hours).
3. Turning data into recommendations and measuring their effect (3 hours).
4. Presenting to the specialty group and the leadership board (3 hours).

Trainer and assessor certification

Everyone who teaches or assesses completes a 4-hour course on running a module, giving feedback and scoring. Before assessing, each assessor scores 3 sample cases and must agree with the QA reviewer within 5 points. Assessors repeat this calibration every quarter.

Leadership track

The growth plan opens about 14 team lead and 7 manager seats, and the Academy prepares internal candidates for them before they are posted.

Course	Who can enrol	Content	Format	Assessment
Team Lead readiness	L3 and above	Coaching and feedback; running the daily huddle and rebalancing work; QA reviews and coaching plans; settlement decision rights and approvals; deadlines and escalation; people policies	6 sessions of 2 hours, plus 4 weeks covering for a team lead	Coaching assessment: an observed 1:1 coaching session and a workload rebalancing case, scored by the chair, a manager and a team lead
Manager readiness	Team leads with 12 months in the role, and L4s	Performance management and scorecards; Net Recovery and reporting; in-house hiring and onboarding; change management; running a portfolio; presenting to the leadership board	8 sessions of 2 hours, plus 1 quarter shadowing a portfolio owner	Presents one monthly portfolio report to the leadership board; panel interview with the director or an assistant director

Completing a course makes a person eligible to apply; it does not guarantee a post. Seats are filled by internal posting first, with the committee shortlisting and the director and assistant directors approving.

Assessment, awarding and promotion

Every badge and promotion follows the same published steps, and every decision is recorded in ClickUp with the evidence behind it.

Earning a badge:

1. **Enrol.** The team lead requests the course in ClickUp, and the chair places the person in the next cohort based on the team badge grid.
2. **Module.** The person attends the classroom hours and passes the end-of-module check, at 80% or higher.
3. **Supervised production.** A badge-holder signs off each case in ClickUp until the case count is met.
4. **Assessment.** Within 10 business days of the request, a Badge Panel scores the practical test plus a random sample of the supervised cases. The panel is the QA reviewer plus 2 assessors from other teams.
5. **Award.** The chair confirms the badge, ClickUp routing switches on the same day, and any allowance starts from the next pay cycle.

When an assessment fails: the panel writes down the gaps. The person gets at least 10 business days of targeted practice and one retake. A second failure means a new supervised production set, at half the original case count, before another attempt.

Keeping a badge: the matrix rules apply.

- One review below the keep threshold triggers a coaching plan.
- Two reviews in a row below it suspend the badge.
- A badge unused for 6 months needs a refresher and 10 supervised cases.
- The committee reviews suspensions monthly and reinstates a badge once it is re-earned.

Promotions (quarterly):

1. At quarter end, ClickUp lists everyone who meets the badge and performance requirements for the next level.
2. The chair and 2 managers from outside each person's team confirm every case.
3. Promotions take effect on the first day of the next month, with the new portfolio tier starting the same day.
4. Anyone eligible but not promoted gets written reasons and a target quarter.

Appeals: one appeal per decision, filed within 10 business days and heard by committee members who did not make the original decision. The result is final for that quarter.

Rollout and yearly calendar

The Academy is set up before the new teams launch, so that placement in January 2027 runs on published criteria and calibrated assessors.

Wave	When	Who	What	Done when
Set-up	Oct–Nov 2026	Committee	Appoint the chair and members; certify trainers and assessors; publish the curriculum and course materials	Every course has a trainer, materials and calibrated assessors
0 · US desk and tickets	Nov 2026	US desk (7), negotiators (27), bridge leads (2)	HIPAA, each Gateway action, ticket procedure and escalation; the ticket checklist	Same-day completion and 98% first-pass tickets in the December parallel run
1 · Fast track	Jan 2027	Everyone	Assessment for badges people already use daily; training on ClickUp routing and the deadline board	Every specialist has a badge record and a provisional level
2 · Core skills	Mar–Jun 2027	Anyone missing a core badge	Billers learn C2; negotiators and coders learn C1, C3 and C4; 4 protected hours a week	All 5 core badges by June 30, 2027
3 · Advanced	Jul 2027 on	L2 and above	A1, A2, A3 and A4 cohorts, set from the team badge grid	At least 2 holders of every badge in every team
New hires	Monthly from 2027	Cohorts of 4–6	2-week onboarding, then the L1 path	On track for L2 at 6 months

Committee calendar:

Cadence	What happens	Who
Weekly	30-minute training check: cohorts, supervised production backlog, assessments due	Chair and trainers
Monthly	New-hire cohort starts on the first Monday; committee meeting; team badge grid published; Academy report sent and presented	Full committee
Quarterly	Promotion panel; assessor calibration; team lead rotation; review of pass marks with QA	Chair, manager members, QA reviewer
Yearly	Curriculum review against changes in rules, payers and coding guidelines; committee renewal	Committee, with the director

Academy KPIs and reporting

The chair reports these every month: in writing to the director and assistant directors, and in person at the leadership board meeting, with recommendations for the board to act on.

KPI	Target	Measured
Specialists holding all 5 core badges	100% by June 30, 2027	Monthly
Teams with 2 or more holders of every badge	100%; no gap open for more than 30 days	Monthly
New hires reaching L2 within 6 months	80% or more	Per cohort
First-attempt assessment pass rate	75–90% (higher suggests the test is too easy)	Monthly
QA of newly badged staff in their first 90 days	At or above the badge's keep threshold	Monthly
Deadlines missed by newly badged staff	Zero	Monthly

KPI	Target	Measured
Assessment turnaround	10 business days or less from request	Monthly
Training hours delivered against plan	95% or more, with protected hours kept	Monthly
Badge suspensions	Under 5% of active badges per quarter	Quarterly
Assessor agreement with the QA reviewer	Within 5 points	Quarterly
Promotions decided on time; appeals closed	100% within the window; appeals within 10 business days	Quarterly
Trainee rating of courses	4 out of 5 or higher	Per course

Monthly Academy report:

1. The team badge grid, with gaps and the plan to close them.
2. Cohorts in progress and assessments passed and failed.
3. New-hire progress against the 6-month plan.
4. Quality signals: QA of new holders, suspensions, critical errors.
5. Feedback from the coding quality, denials and IDR performance owners that changes the curriculum.
6. Recommendations and decisions needed from the board.